

# 8th Grade American Studies

## Course Syllabus & Standards Map

Mr. B (Benaderet) · Alderwood Middle School · 2025-2026 · Aligned to the WA Social Studies Learning Standards (2019)

**Updated for next year:** a weekly “Now & Then” current events routine, the new “Big Decisions” deliberation project in the Early Republic, economics named explicitly where it is already taught, and a year-end Civic Action capstone that closes the civic action standard.

### Course description

American Studies is a chronological study of United States history from the eve of the Revolution through the Civil War, reaching toward Reconstruction. Along the way students examine our multicultural heritage, our economic development, and the rights and responsibilities of citizens. Every student completes a Classroom Based Assessment in civics. Reading, writing, discussion, and research skills are reinforced continuously, all year long.

### Skills, the civics CBA, and grading

The Social Studies Skills strand (SSS1 to SSS4) runs through every unit. Students learn to weigh evidence, judge sources, deliberate public issues, and build thesis driven products with proper citations. A weekly current events routine (“Now & Then”) connects the news to each unit and meets the history to today standard, H4.6-8.3, across the year.

**Civics CBA:** The required Classroom Based Assessment in civics is the SCOTUS debate in Unit 6.

Students argue a constitutional question through a landmark case, write opening and closing statements, and cite their evidence on a works cited page.

**Standards based grading:** Work is scored on a four level proficiency scale: 4 Exemplary, 3 Proficient, 2 Progressing, 1 Beginning.

## Units and standards map

Approximate week numbers are within each semester. Standard codes: C = Civics, E = Economics, G = Geography, H = History, SSS = Social Studies Skills.

### Semester 1

| Unit                                  | Wks   | Essential question and focus                                                                                                      | Signature work                                         | WA Standards                                                           |
|---------------------------------------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Unit 0</b><br>Identity & Community | 1-2   | <i>“Who gets to define what an American is?”</i><br>Identity, community, and the values we share.                                 | Life Map; Classroom Constitution                       | C4.6-8.4 · C1.6-8.3 · SSS3 · H4.6-8.3                                  |
| <b>Unit 1</b><br>The 13 Colonies      | 3-5   | <i>“How did geography shape colonial life, and whose stories get told?”</i><br>Three regions, settlement, and contact.            | Region study; Jamestown & Mayflower source analysis    | G1.6-8.5 · G2.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.6 · H3.6-8.4 · SSS2                       |
| <b>Unit 2</b><br>The Triangle Trade   | 6-7   | <i>“How did this trade build wealth, and at whose expense?”</i><br>The paradox of liberty; profit and human cost.                 | Triangle Trade simulation + economics debrief          | E1.6-8.3 · E2.6-8.1 · E4.6-8.5 · H3.6-8.4 · SSS1                       |
| <b>Unit 3</b><br>Revolutionary Voices | 7-12  | <i>“What made colonists seek independence, and whose voices are left out?”</i><br>Causes, the Declaration, and overlooked people. | Voices of the Revolution podcast; Declaration analysis | H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5 · H3.6-8.4 · C1.6-8.3 · C1.6-8.4 · SSS2 · SSS4     |
| <b>Unit 4</b><br>The Constitution     | 13-18 | <i>“How do you build a government that limits its own power?”</i><br>Convention, branches, Bill of Rights, and tribal treaties.   | Constitution study; Treaty of Greenville CER           | C1.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.5 · C2.6-8.6 · C1.6-8.4 · C3.6-8.3 · SSS4 |
| <b>Unit 5</b>                         | 19    | <i>“Which founding ideals were worth</i>                                                                                          | Capstone project (choice                               | H4.6-8.3 · C1.6-8.4 · C4.6-8.4 · SSS4                                  |

| Unit                   | Wks | Essential question and focus                                                   | Signature work      | WA Standards |
|------------------------|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|--------------|
| Semester 1<br>Capstone |     | <i>fighting for, and who had access?"</i><br>The struggle for American ideals. | menu, gallery walk) |              |

## Semester 2

| Unit                                     | Wks   | Essential question and focus                                                                                                                                | Signature work                                                                          | WA Standards                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Unit 6</b><br>SCOTUS (Civics CBA)     | 1-4   | <i>"How does the Court decide what the Constitution means, and who gets to be an American?"</i><br>Landmark cases and judicial review.                      | Constitutional Issues<br>CBA: SCOTUS debate (opening & closing statements, works cited) | C2.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.5 · C1.6-8.4 · C4.6-8.4 · SSS3 · SSS4                       |
| <b>Unit 7</b><br>The Early Republic      | 6-9   | <i>"How did the young nation handle its first big decisions?"</i><br>Precedents, parties, foreign policy, and expansion.                                    | The Big Decisions<br>deliberation + art project                                         | H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5 · H2.6-8.7 · C3.6-8.5 · C3.6-8.6 · E3.6-8.3 · SSS2        |
| <b>Unit 8</b><br>Westward Expansion      | 11-14 | <i>"What drove the nation westward, and who paid the price?"</i><br>Removal, Manifest Destiny, and conflict.                                                | Jackson CER; Trail of Tears perspectives; expansion maps                                | H1.6-8.6 · G1.6-8.6 · G2.6-8.8 · H2.6-8.6 · H3.6-8.4 · C3.6-8.6 · SSS4        |
| <b>Unit 9</b><br>The Civil War           | 15-20 | <i>"How did North and South become two worlds, and why did compromise fail?"</i><br>Sectionalism, slavery, the war, and toward Reconstruction.              | North/South stations; African American experience gallery walk; causation writing       | H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5 · H2.6-8.7 · H3.6-8.5 · E4.6-8.5 · E2.6-8.5 · SSS3 · SSS4 |
| <b>Capstone</b><br>Year-End Civic Action | Final | <i>"How will you carry a founding ideal into an issue you care about today?"</i><br>Built from the year-long Now & Then log and assembled in the last week. | Civic Action project: a claim plus a real action, from a choice menu                    | C4.6-8.5 · C4.6-8.4 · H4.6-8.3 · SSS3 · SSS4                                  |

**Reinforced all year:** Social Studies Skills (SSS1 reasoning, SSS2 research, SSS3 deliberation, SSS4 products with citations) and the weekly "Now & Then" current events connection (H4.6-8.3).

## What the year covers

Across the year the course gives strong, repeated coverage of the History strand (chronology and eras, causation, and multiple perspectives) and the Civics strand (founding ideals, the structure of government, checks and balances, and tribal treaties), anchored by the required civics CBA. Economics is taught inside the simulations and units (the triangle trade, the new nation's economy, and the divided economies of North and South). Geography lives in the colonial regions, removal, and westward expansion. The Social Studies Skills strand is practiced in every unit. The weekly current events routine and the year-end Civic Action capstone close the two thinnest spots from the earlier standards review: connecting history to today (H4.6-8.3) and civic action on a public issue (C4.6-8.5).

**Scope note:** The year reliably reaches the Civil War and the start of Reconstruction. The later eras named in the broader course frame (Industrialization, Immigration, and the Reform movements) are the natural place to extend the course in future years.

**Source:** *OSPI K to 12 Social Studies Learning Standards (2019), Grades 6 to 8, and the OSPI Recommended Scope and Sequence (2020).* Standard codes match the interactive Standards Progression Map on Mr. B's class site.